



Law, Yao Hua

Science, Environment & Data Journalist, Insect Ecologist (Ph.D. 2010)

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[LinkedIn](#) · [Journalism Portfolio](#) · [Research Papers](#)

Newsroom co-founder, editor and journalist since 2014. Deep editorial expertise in rainforest investigations and storytelling — including award-winning work in Malaysia that stopped illegal logging projects and helped indigenous communities secure land rights in court. Proven record mentoring journalists at all levels, from first-time reporters to mid-career editors. Nine international and national awards spanning data journalism, investigative reporting, and longform narrative. Active volunteer and president of a Malaysian charity organization (350 members) in 2021-2024.

WORK EXPERIENCE

Nieman Fellow — [Nieman Foundation for Journalism](#), Harvard University (2025–2026)

Co-Founder, Editor & Journalist — [Macaranga Media](#) (2019–2025)

Freelance Science & Environment Journalist / Podcast Producer (2014–2023) — 15+ international outlets including The Atlantic, Science, Science News, Mosaic, Nature

Radio Producer & Host — BFM 89.9 (2014–2016)

Senior Lecturer — Faculty of Agriculture, Universiti Putra Malaysia (2011–2014)

Ph.D. Researcher — Dept of Entomology, University of California, Davis (2006–2010)

EDUCATION

Ph.D. Entomology — University of California, Davis, USA (2006–2010)

B.Sc. Environmental Biology — McGill University, Canada (2002–2006)

LANGUAGES

Full proficiency: English · Mandarin · Malay · Cantonese · Hainanese

EDITORIAL LEADERSHIP & MANAGEMENT

Nieman Fellow | *Nieman Foundation for Journalism, Harvard University* | 2025–2026

- Fully funded fellowship developing the foundation for a food journalism newsroom in Malaysia; built '[Fate of Our Forests](#)', an interactive platform tracking changes in Malaysian forest reserves

Co-Founder & Editor | *Macaranga Media (independent environmental newsroom)* | 2019–2025

- Co-directed all editorial output of Malaysia's first and only [environmental newsroom](#) — commissioning, assigning, structuring, and editing longform investigations, data stories, and features across beats including rainforests, wildlife trafficking, pollution, and environmental justice
- Oversaw a team of journalists and contributors; set editorial standards, managed story pipelines, and safeguarded editorial independence against corporate and government influence
- Established Macaranga's editorial identity and brand strategy; coded the newsroom website; built and ran reader membership program
- Led newsroom to win 6 global and national awards and secured grants and fellowships exceeding USD 134,000

Grant Lead | *EU Delegation to Malaysia / Macaranga* | 2024–2025

- Authored proposal and won a USD 70,000 grant from the European Delegation to Malaysia to fund environment reporting and training
- Managed all deliverables, timelines, quarterly and final reporting, accounting, and external communications with institutional partners

MENTORING JOURNALISTS

Macaranga Environmental Journalism Programs (2020–2025)

- Developed and directed the 2025 Environmental Journalism Workshop (4-day) for 12 Malaysian journalists, followed by a 3-month mentorship for 5 participants — including reporters who had never covered the environment; two mentees introduced new storytelling methods to their newsrooms
- Developed and ran the 2025 Environmental Reporting Mentorship for 50+ students across 2 Malaysian universities; 5 teams received 2-month mentorships and published environmental stories
- Co-developed and ran the 2022 Environmental Journalism Workshop for 11 journalists and 1 activist; the activist became a journalist and subsequently won a national journalism award in 2024 under continued mentorship
- Co-designed and ran the Sprouts program (2020–2022), recruiting and training Malaysians with no journalism background to produce 16 published stories; many participants went on to careers in environmental communication

Youth Leadership Mentorship

- Advisor (2011–2021) to the Youth Division of a Malaysia NGO; mentored 20 young members (aged 15–25) annually and developed structured systems for planning, evaluating, and improving community programming

RAINFOREST INVESTIGATIONS: SELECTED IMPACT

- [Pulitzer Centre Rainforest Investigations Network Fellow](#) (2021, 2022): Year-long investigations exposing illegal deforestation projects linked to Malaysian royal family members, and systemic failures in nationwide plantation schemes — resulting in stopped projects and indigenous land rights secured in court
- ['The Climate-Friendly Virgin in Terengganu'](#) (Macaranga, 2024): Examined a proposed oil palm project clearing one of Malaysia's last virgin peat swamp forests; the government rejected the project within a week of publication
- ['Forest Plantations in Reserves: Quick to Cut, Slow to Grow'](#) (Macaranga, 2022): Sigma Award-recognized investigation exposing widespread clearing of natural forests abandoned without replanting; part of a multi-story investigative series
- ['Cut, Carved, and Cleared: When Big Forests Go'](#) (Macaranga, 2021): Deeply researched feature examining the aftermath of large-scale deforestation on community, economy, and wildlife; most commented story in Macaranga's history
- Pulitzer Centre Rainforest Journalism Network grant (2020): Funded explanatory features on the structural drivers of forest loss in Malaysia

JOURNALISM SKILLS & FORMATS

Beat expertise

Rainforests and deforestation · Biodiversity and wildlife · Public health · Science and data · Indigenous communities · Climate crisis

Formats

- Longform narrative: Award-winning stories from 1,500 to 4,000 words; 3-part series of 10,000 words
- Data and investigative journalism: Quantitative, geospatial, and hypothesis-driven analysis; built a forest reserve monitoring platform
- Interactive storytelling: Coded interactive features (HTML/CSS/JS) including Macaranga's [rare earth mining interactive](#) and [highway socio-economic impact story](#)
- Radio and podcast: Produced and hosted daily shows at BFM 89.9; produced 40-minute radio documentaries; produced own science journalism podcast (Monsoon)
- Photography: Field photography integrated into longform features (e.g., [Macaranga's arowana stories](#))

JOURNALISM AWARDS

- Sigma Award (2023) — International data journalism award for portfolio. Judge citation: "Data journalism in Malaysia has been elevated to another level."
- Malaysian Press Institute — Gold, Environmental Reporting (2022, 2023); Silver, Investigative Reporting (2023); Bronze, Feature Writing (2023)
- One World Media Award, Print (2020) — Narrative feature on snakebite in Indonesia prompted the government to form a national venom research program
- Personalized Medicine Journalism Competition, First Prize (2019)
- Asian Scientist Writing Prize, First Prize (2015)